



finalist Fritz, 6-3, 6-4, and Alcaraz, 6-4, 6-1. "It's tougher to have a one-handed backhand in an era when power is king, especially on return of serve," rightly said Courier.

What about No. 3 Zverev, the 2021 Tokyo Olympic gold medallist and ATP Finals champion in 2018 and 2021? The 6'6" German is a member of the 'lost '90s generation' that includes Grigor Dimitrov and the retired Dominic Thiem. The trio futilely chased the Big Three and now rarely beats Alcaraz and Sinner. Zverev has a big first serve and rock-solid backhand, but his downfall is more mental than technical, though his forehand lacks the wrist action to hit hard shots down the line.

"He can play great until the time comes when he needs to keep playing that way, and then he pulls back because of the pressure," said Courier. "The only way to get better is to hit out during matches. The practice court is not the same." Zverev failed to make the semifinals

when the bolder-hitting Felix Auger-Aliassime defeated him 6-4, 7-6(4). That result extended FAA's terrific record in tiebreaks to 32-14 this year.

Nicknamed 'Demon' for his relentless competitiveness, De Minaur (left) blew a 5-3 third-set lead against Musetti in their 7-5, 3-6, 7-5 round-robin match. The undersized (6'0" and 160 pounds) Australian, who has suffered several close, heartbreaking defeats this year, confided, "I think it's probably a good thing I don't express my feelings right now because they're quite dark.... It's getting to a point where mentally it's killing me."

The 'Demon' exorcised his demons and redeemed himself with a rewarding 7-6(3), 6-3 victory over Fritz to make the semifinals for the first time. De Minaur, whose first serve averaged 125 mph, faster than usually rocket-serving Fritz's 124 mph, told *Tennis Channel*, "I was going to live or die by the sword and win or lose my way."

That leaves Fritz, who led the ATP Tour in aces, reached the Wimbledon semifinals, and ambushed Alcaraz 6-3, 6-2 at the Laver Cup in September. Alcaraz avenged that loss at the ATP Finals with a 6-7(2), 7-5, 6-3 win. The huge disparity was at the net, where the more athletic and skilful Spaniard won 23 of 26 points compared with only 12 of 30 for the American.

As Courier ruefully recalled, "In the era I played, if you were the No. 1 American [man], you were probably No. 1 in the world." How times have changed since Sampras, Andre Agassi, and Courier reigned! Andy Roddick was the last American to win a Major and rank No. 1, way back in 2003.

Sinner simply brought too much groundstroke power for even the speedy De Minaur to reach and return in their predictable 7-5, 6-2 semifinal. Sinner blasted a backhand down-the-line winner to break serve for 5-2, the floodgates opened, and that allowed Sinner to work on the new weapons in his game, such as 'crush and rush' to attack De

Minaur's second serve.

De Minaur idolised two-time Major champ Lleyton Hewitt, a ferocious competitor he emulated. "You want juniors to watch De Minaur's effort," said *Tennis Channel* analyst Paul Annacone. "I don't think anyone tries harder." Sinner also earned praise from Courier, renowned for his fighting spirit. "Behind those eyes is a stone-cold assassin. Sinner reminds me of [eight-time Major winner Ivan] Lendl. He's absolutely out for blood."

Alcaraz, with dyed blond hair above his natural dark brown, faced a tough semifinal foe in Auger-Aliassime. The resurgent Canadian, now 25 and recently married to the equestrian Nina Ghaibi, whom he met seven years ago, owned the most indoor wins, 85, since 2020.

Alcaraz — who used a psychologist from 8 to 14 to focus on enjoyment rather than winning — admitted he suffered from nerves in his last match due to the pressure to clinch the No. 1 ranking.

Charlie, as his friends call him, showed no nerves as he showcased his entire repertoire of dazzling shots to overwhelm FAA with 13 winners (against only two unforced errors) in the 6-2 opening set. "It looked like something out of *The Matrix* or a video game," said the awed Annacone. The stunning performance also impressed Alcaraz. "This is the best match I've ever played on an indoor court — against someone like Felix."

That set up another Sincaraz dream final. Alcaraz had won four of the previous five this year, with their engrossing classic at Roland Garros by far the best match of the year and the greatest French Open match ever. In a dramatic smorgasbord of shot-making, Alcaraz fended off three championship points to overcome Sinner 4-6, 6-7(4), 6-4, 7-6(3), 7-6(2).

Before the eagerly anticipated showdown, *Tennis Channel's* Prakash Amritraj posed the question, "How do you rob Alcaraz of his offence? You can play exceptional defence, or you can play more